18

I Have a Dream

As the children started growing up, we began to think about their future. My early struggles as an athlete were always at the back of my mind, and I didn't want them to enter a field that offered little money and security. Like my father, it was my desire that the children should receive a good education and earn professional degrees, so that they could become doctors or engineers, solid and conservative careers that would reap dividends in the future. The girls were progressing well at school, but Jeev was a cause of some concern.

Right from a very young age, Jeev had started to show a distinct inclination towards sports; more significant was the fact that he was demonstrating a great aptitude for it as well. He was an excellent sprinter as I noticed when I was the chief guest at one of his school's functions—he was studying at St John's School in Chandigarh then. I saw him run so swiftly that he was far ahead of the other boys. The spectators were most impressed and remarked that he would surely break my records one day. When he was studying at Bishop Cotton in Simla, he was the captain of the school's cricket team, and I remember what Kapil Dev's coach, D.P.S. Azad who worked under me, said, 'Sir, if you allow me to train Jeev, I can assure you that he will be a member of Indian cricket team in just a few years.' Then I recalled Kairon Sahib's wise words about genes, and realized how true they were proving to be. Our daughters, too, were competent sportspersons—Sonia was a superb tennis player, while Aleeza and Mona were good swimmers.

Life can often be unexpected. When I first developed an interest in golf it was as late as 1969, but little did I realize how this game would dominate our lives.